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Comparative Public Theology and Interreligious Education in the Age of Religious Pluralism

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Abstract: The post-modern era is characterized by a structural religious pluralism, whereby the public dimension of religion has re-emerged as a prominent feature after the relative obscurity of the modern period. In the context of Christianity, the contribution of religion to the common good has been reflected upon in the extensive and profound field of Public Theology. Since its inception in the 1980s, this vast area of studies has encompassed a wide range of topics, including politics, civil society, economics, social issues, and justice. However, the interreligious dimension of public theology appears to be less developed. This is linked, firstly, to the discovery of the public dimension of neighbouring religions and, secondly, to the clarification of the relationship between this and Christian Public Theology. It is evident that the focus of this discussion is the development of a Comparative Public Theology as Interreligious Public Theology. This is a theology that considers the comparative study of religions in a pluralistic context, with the public aspect as its background. On this basis, the contribution has two main aims. Firstly, to identify the field of interreligious public theology, and secondly to concretise it by exploring the field of education from an interreligious and public perspective, i.e., as a contribution to the common good.

Keywords: pluralism; public theology; comparative public theology; religious education; interreligious education; common good

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Academic Editors: Francis-Vincent Anthony and Gnana Patrick

Received: 6 February 2025
Revised: 23 February 2025
Accepted: 28 February 2025
Published: 2 March 2025

Citation: Sabetta, Gaetano. 2025. Comparative Public Theology and Interreligious Education in the Age of Religious Pluralism. *Religions* 16: 313. https://doi.org/10.3390/rel16030313

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1. Introduction: Common Good in the Plural Scenario

The contemporary era is on a steep crest of history because the world, understood as a global society, will be very different from what it was at the end of the 20th century. Pope Francis (2019) himself foreshadowed this scenario of change when he stated: "ours is not an age of change, but a change of epoch".

From a global and national perspective, several sociologists have defined our era in terms of local globalisation (glocalisation), which is marked profoundly by pluralisation (Robertson 1995). This pluralism is characterised by two dualisms. Firstly, there is the coexistence of religions in a single social and public space. Secondly, there is the dualism between religions and the secular in a sphere that is no longer solely private but also public (Berger 2020). The mutation in question entails a scientific rethinking, moving away from the traditional notions of society undergoing modernisation and religion becoming increasingly secularised. Instead, the contemporary era is characterised by a globalised society and a pluralistic approach to religion (Beyer 2020). In this new pluralistic context, the marginalisation of religious perspectives from academic discourse and the public sphere has gradually receded, creating space for a new religious presence in the public domain. This protagonism lends itself to a dual interpretation, given the ambivalence underlying the

religious phenomenon. On the one hand, there is the destructive and even fundamentalist dimension present in various religious traditions. On the other hand, there is the essential function of edifying a process of mutual understanding and social cohesion within plural societies, which require this unity in diversity and this harmony between different people to live in a peaceful coexistence within a culture of mutual recognition and acceptance.

The categories of intercultural and interreligious dialogue appear to delineate the route recommended by a significant number of scholars in the interdisciplinary field and politicians as a means of attaining social harmony and mutual recognition—two fundamental tenets necessary for the sustenance of any community. (cf. Council of Europe 2008).

The theological response to a multitude of issues that impinge upon the common good and the lives of entire populations in the social, economic, political, educational, cultural, ecological and religious spheres, with reference to the question of coexistence and the conditions for a good life, has constituted the subject of what is known as Public Theology in the Christian tradition. A theology that eschews parochial, individualistic and ecclesiastical considerations, and that is not limited to the use of a language accessible only to experts. Instead, it addresses issues of common interest and, in the pursuit of the common good, challenges people and institutions beyond the confines of the ecclesial enclosure. Martin Marty was the first to employ the term "public theology" to describe sociological analyses of civil religion within the American context (Day and Kim 2017). Furthermore, Brietenberg, to elucidate its scope, provides the following definition:

> Public theology is thus theologically informed public discourse about public issues, addressed to the church, synagogue, mosque, temple or other religious body, as well as the larger public or publics, argued in ways than can be evaluated and judged by publicly available warrants and criteria (Brietenberg 2003, p. 66).

In the context of contemporary pluralism, the limitations of Public Christian Theology are becoming increasingly apparent on two sides. Methodologically, it carries the risk of colonising others, even when this is not the intention, unless it is open to the comparative study of religions and its methodology. In terms of content, public theology has primarily addressed ethical concerns, with relatively limited engagement with the dimension of religious pluralism and interreligious education.

To address the question of method, it is necessary, firstly, to discover the public dimension of neighbouring religions and, secondly, to clarify the relationship between this and Christian Public Theology. This will be done in the third section of this paper, after introducing the field of Public Theology in the next paragraph. To address the question of content, that is how to develop a public theology of interreligious education, this study will pursue two key aims. The first will be to delineate the domain of a Comparative Public Theology as Interreligious Public Theology (Cornille 2022), in the fourth section. The second will be to substantiate this domain through an investigation of the role of education in an interreligious and public context, thereby contributing to the common good in a pluralistic society, in the fifth section.

It is evident that in order to accomplish these objectives, it is imperative to delineate the concept of public theology from an interreligious standpoint. Subsequently, the capacity of religious and interreligious education to nurture the common good must be assessed. To address both these gaps, it is therefore essential to adopt an interreligious and comparative approach. This entails the development of a Comparative Public Theology (Chung 2018) or even a Comparative Theological Paradigm for Public Pastoral Theology (Bidwell 2015). The conclusion will therefore be an attempt to identify the contours of Comparative Public Theology.

2. Public Theology and Its Evolution

The concept of 'public theology' has undergone a significant evolution in recent decades, capturing the attention of numerous theologians. It has emerged as a fruitful and effective framework for articulating a form of theology that is particularly relevant in the present situation. This growth may be attributed to a desire to counter the ideological influence exerted by the privatisation of religion, on the one hand, and to challenge the perceived limitations of politicised and public religion, on the other (Cady 2014).

Public theology, therefore, will always move within the sacred/secular polarity in an attempt to redraw its contours. This is a first step, however, in which theologians like David Tracy (2014) question the meaning of *public* in public theology, and philosophers like Jürgen Habermas (2008) provide an epistemological reference in relation to the public secular sphere and religions, paving the way for multiple modernities other than the dry sacred/secular alternative, in which religions have a public role and secularity is open to the religious sphere.

The subsequent step is to identify and comprehend the religious plurality within the public context of a public theology. It is precisely at this locus that there emerges the opportunity for the comparative dimension of public theology. According to Chung (2018), Habermas' contribution with his politics of mutual recognition, his acceptance of pluralism and religious tolerance: "provides a tool for a public comparative theology in the service of furnishing an epistemic stance with regards the secular public sphere and other religions... One consequence is that public theology can then exhibit the marks of a comparative study of religions". Similarly, the contribution of the theologian and philosopher Raimond Panikkar (2022) is important. In his seminal work *Sacred Secularity*, he attempts to transcend the prevailing dichotomy between the sacred, as embodied in various religious traditions, and the secular. Instead, he seeks to contemplate the fundamental essence of secularity, positing that the sacred, in its manifold expressions, lies at the foundation of this phenomenon, no longer in opposition but rather in harmony with the secular.

Therefore, while public theology is frequently defined in reference to its relationship with Christianity, its fundamental tenets are not exclusive to a single religious tradition (Hosen 2012). Its future lies in its capacity to respond to the plurality marked by the two dualisms (many religions and sacred/secular). In the opinion of Sandal (2012), the notion of public theology furnishes a valuable framework for scholars engaged in the field of international relations, enabling them to engage in discourse pertaining to the inter- and intra-faith dynamics of economic, social, and political relations. It is important to note that these dynamics extend beyond the Abrahamic traditions, encompassing Dharmic and Chinese religions as well (Chow 2018).

The focus of this discussion is an area of research termed "constructive public theology" characterised by its interactive social process, which involves faith communities and different publics (Day and Kim 2017).

A frequently cited exemplar of "constructive public theology" is the pastoral letter published by the United States Conference of Catholic Bishops (1986). Entitled *Economic Justice for All*, this document is notable for its comprehensive analysis of economic issues. It was published in the context of the laissez-faire economic policies developed by President Ronald Reagan, which, in combination with globalisation, were causing rapid and unexpected structural changes in the economy. A notable element of the document was its ability to address two distinct audiences: the Catholic public and policymakers. The document's language was meticulously chosen to ensure accessibility and credibility for both the religious community and the individuals with expertise and influence in policymaking. This process marked a shift from a theology addressing society, often from a perspective

of moral privilege, to a theology built with and through engagement with the diverse publics as responsible citizens (believers and non-believers) in civil and plural societies who have a power and a duty in building the common good. The same inclusive approach and spirit can be found, *mutatis mutandis*, in the *A Document on Human Fraternity for World Peace and Coexistence*, drafted together by a Catholic and Muslim delegation and jointly signed by Pope Francis and the Grand Imam of Al-Azhar Ahmad Al-Tayyeb (Pope Francis and Al-Tayyeb 2019). It is a document capable of addressing different publics (Catholics, Muslims, non-believers) with the aim of forming citizens committed to the common good.

Recent advances in the field of public theology have not entailed the establishment of a rigid doctrinal framework. Notwithstanding this diversity, there exist certain traits deemed indispensable in the process of "constructive public theology".

Firstly, public theology is incarnational. Consequently, the objective of theological endeavour is to ascertain God's intentions for all of creation, i.e., the common good (a holistic understanding of salvation where the whole human being, the whole humanity and the whole creation are involved).

Secondly, public theology is an endeavour that is perpetually engaged in addressing its reflection to various publics, each of which is unique and distinct, by means of posing questions and stimulating reflection. These publics include the church, the academy, society at large (Tracy 1981, pp. 2–5), economic sectors, the political sphere, civil society, social spheres, the educational sector and the public domain (Kim 2011, pp. 10–15).

Public theology is interdisciplinary in nature. Theology must draw inspiration from the social sciences, economics, law, history and anthropology.

Another distinguishing feature of public theology is its dialogical nature. This attribute appears to be inherent, given that it is a theology that no longer addresses society directly, but is constituted in conjunction with various publics. However, it should be noted that this dialogical nature is neither immediate nor universally accepted. Firstly, dialogicality recalls openness and thus issues of self-criticism, transparency and accountability/responsibility. Secondly, dialogicality relates to its ability to engage in dialogue with other theologies within a plural context. This capacity to engage in interreligious and comparative discourse is arguably integral to the definition of public theology. Therefore, its public character is shown in its openness to a comparative approach and to interreligious learning, especially when it comes to the development of a public theology of interreligious education.

The last characteristic of public theology is its globality. Public theologians and publications in this field invariably underscore that the focus of their reflections encompasses a broad spectrum of issues impacting humanity. Issues such as peace, human rights, integral human development, justice, national and global religious and interreligious education, war, and environmental concerns are among the political, social, economic, and civic domains that intersect with the concept of holistic salvation and the common good (cf. Day and Kim 2017, pp. 10–18).

3. Public Theology, Religions and Education

Within the framework of public theology, there appears to have been insufficient attention paid to the relationship between Christian public theology and other religions in terms of their contribution to the common good.

Conversely, it appears pertinent to acknowledge an interreligious and comparative dimension inherent within public theology. Public theology is not confined to Christianity, and it is conceivable to discern traces of it within world religions. Concomitantly, there is the potential for the acquisition of knowledge from these disparate perspectives, as they articulate their contribution to the public good.

Additionally, the evident interconnection of public theology with educational perspectives and contexts has been largely disregarded in the current discourse surrounding public theology. The role of religions in and for the public sphere, and especially for cohesion in a plural society, is always viewed ambivalently. While some perceive religions as sources of division, dissension and social instability, others advocate for their unifying and pacifying potential. From the latter perspective, the promotion of interreligious dialogue and understanding is posited as a means of enhancing the common good and mitigating extremist impulses. It can thus be posited that the promotion of interreligious dialogue and understanding is a significant component of public theology. In this regard, religious education and interreligious learning appear to be of paramount importance.

To elaborate further, two fundamental issues can be identified: firstly, the comprehension of public theology from diverse religious viewpoints; secondly, the challenge of interreligious dialogue and learning. Therefore, the necessity of religious education and interreligious learning for public theology, with a view to cultivating the common good in society. The initial issue is instrumental to the subsequent one, insofar as the public dimension of differing religions constitutes the basis upon which an interreligious educational and learning process is to be built.

3.1. Public Theology and Religions

In addressing the question of the contribution of the Jewish religion to global well-being, the concept of *Tikkun Olam* is arguably the most frequently cited (Worch 2018). Literally, *Tikkun Olam* means "repairing" or "mending of the world". Consequently, the historical roots and contemporary significance of the Jewish concept of *Tikkun Olam* as a present-day concept for Jewish engagement in the pursuit of the common good is both real and consistent. Therefore, it may be suggested that this constitutes the genesis of a Jewish public theology.

Sahin (2018, p. 38)'s contributions to the fields of theology and education have led him to affirm that: "Today, more than ever, we need to develop an engaging 'critical Islamic public theology' that is able to elaborate on the educational vision of Islam so that its humanizing vision of upholding justice, showing gratitude and protecting the dignity and welfare of all can become apparent". This is evidenced by his observation of the Qur'an's core message to humanity and its vocabulary being embedded in a universe of embodied ethical meaning, merciful acceptance of diversity and searching for peaceful coexistence. The ethical logic of the Qur'anic narrative is easily perceptible: the act of benevolence on the part of the divine being is characterised as the bestowal of life upon humanity, with the expectation of gratitude and recognition in return. Those who express gratitude to God become Muslims/mu'mins (literally, those who are in a state of peace and gratitude) and are called to reciprocate this goodness towards the other and the entire creation. As articulated by a Prophet's hadith, "He who is unable to express gratitude to people, is unable to express gratitude to the Creator". In Islam, the concept of justice occupies a pivotal role. The Qur'an posits that the fundamental objective underlying the inspiration of numerous prophets is to serve as facilitators for enabling the establishment of justice among humankind (Q 57:25). The Qur'an illuminates the fact that God created humanity as women and men (the same essence) and as people of various religious and cultural orientations, with the intention that humans could be encouraged to acquire knowledge from one another (Q 30:22; 49:13). This suggests that 'difference' is recognised as a positive aspect, which has the potential to serve as an educational catalyst, promoting humanity's openness to dialogue and mutual learning (Q 49:13). In a similar manner, the fundamental teaching of the Qur'an, *tawhid* (acknowledging Oneness of God), signifies the capacity to discern a more profound level of unity and equilibrium within the heterogeneity of life. It is imperative

for humans to strive to comprehend the interconnectedness and interdependence inherent in nature and human existence. This unifying vision of *tawhid* should serve as a guiding principle, facilitating the resolution of differences and potential conflicts. It invites us to transcend our differences and to identify a shared understanding and reach a fair compromise. This entails acknowledging the oneness of the Creator and engaging in virtuous deeds for the benefit of humanity (Q 3:64). In the event of any competitive undertakings, the Qur'an emphasises that such endeavours should be focused on performing good deeds, ensuring the dignity and welfare of all (Q 2:148). In the development of Muslim legal thought, this emphasis on justice and protecting the well-being of all was recognised as a fundamental source of law in Islam (*sharia*), as seen in the concept of serving the common good (*maslaha*). In the context of Islamic ethics and law (*maqasid al-shariah*), classical Muslim scholars have identified five rights that they suggest summarise the ultimate ethos. These five rights are: the rights to protect life, family (progeny), property, religion and human thinking/reasoning capacity. Sahin's experience as an educator within the Islamic context has led him to conceptualise education as a lifelong process of "compassionate transformation", with the overarching objective of fostering human flourishing. This transformative pedagogy, as posited by the author, is designed to cultivate values of critical openness to learning from one another, gratitude, active citizenship and civil engagement, and to guide towards a higher synthesis of mutual respect, spiritual and moral growth.

Heeson Bai (2018) delineates a Buddhist perspective on public theology by stating that Buddhism should be regarded as a system of lifelong education which promotes a post-egoic consciousness. This is a consciousness which is necessary for people who seek the common good through working with each other across the differences in worldviews, meanings, religions and spiritualities. The absence of any sustainable peace is due to humanity remaining at a level of egoic consciousness. It is therefore essential for humanity to mature beyond the egoic and move into a post-egoic, dialogic consciousness. The contribution of Buddhism to this transition is significant, as it provides a framework for transcending the limitations of the egoic consciousness and embracing a post-egoic, dialogic approach. The basis for self–other conflict, competition, both on the large and small scale, is dualistic consciousness, which perceives the world in terms of dichotomies (mind–body, good–bad, right–wrong, I–you, etc.). Most individuals, in most cases, experience egoic states of consciousness characterised by self–other exclusive divisions, a linear perception of time, and a sense of locality. However, experiences of post-egoic consciousness are not as infrequent as is generally assumed. Post-egoic consciousness is defined by the dissolution of conventional boundaries between the self and other, resulting in a permeable and malleable self-concept. This phenomenon can precipitate unconventional, that is, non-ordinary, experiences in the context of everyday life.

From a cognitive perspective, the concept of enlightenment in the Buddhist tradition involves a shift in consciousness, characterised by a transition from a perspective that perceives the world in dichotomous terms, such as self–other, friend–foe, good–bad, moral–immoral, animate–inanimate, and numerous other dualistic or polarising categories, to a perception of a more complex and dynamic interconnection and interpenetration of all phenomena.

From an affective perspective, enlightenment in the Buddhist tradition fosters feelings of *metta*, or love and kindness towards all beings, alongside *karuna*, or compassion for the afflicted, and *mudita*, or joy, in the company of happy individuals. These emotions are experienced in conjunction with a sense of *upekkha*, or equanimity, providing a secure and balanced perspective on one's place in the universe. The state of being enlightened is defined by the stable and sustainable establishment of these feeling states.

The lifelong learning process in Buddhism, known as the Eightfold Path, is considered to be the path to liberation from *samsara*. This process is comprised of eight integrated aspects: Right Understanding, Right Thought, Right Speech, Right Action, Right Livelihood, Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, and Right Concentration. The initial seven elements are constructed to be foundational pillars that underpin Right Concentration. The absence of right concentration, in this case, results in the perpetuation of the ignorance that leads to the belief in an independently existing self, which in turn, is considered to be the root of *samsara*. As indicated previously, the deep dimension of the Eightfold Path can be regarded as a viable means of developing a Buddhist understanding of public theology (Walpola 1974).

3.2. Public Theology and (Inter) Religious Education

The necessity of religious education and interreligious learning for public theology becomes apparent when considering the cultivation of the common good in society. It is acknowledged that one of the most significant contributions that religions can offer to the common good is to mitigate feelings of hostility and estrangement between religions and worldviews, thereby facilitating peaceful coexistence and cooperation. It is contended that this issue should be accorded greater prominence in the domain of public theology. But to engage in a public theology of interreligious education means to explore the synergies of public and comparative theology, that is, to open up the field of comparative public theology. It is not possible to think simply of a public theology for interreligious education, but it is necessary to imagine a Comparative Public Theology for interreligious education, a common space where a dialogue between different public theologies can take place. In drafting the relationship between public and comparative, it is possible to speak of *public* theology as the final cause of the interreligious education process, since it provides it with direction towards the common good. In addition, *comparative* theology may be regarded as the material and formal cause, insofar as it provides the material and modalities that an interreligious education process requires.

4. Comparative Public Theology

4.1. Origins

Comparative Theology (CT) is a relatively recent approach to theological enquiry, despite the term's first utilisation in the 18th century to underscore the potential for formulating an alternative to the apologetic perspective on other religions. In the 19th century, the orientalist Max Müller (1972) employed the term extensively to denote a novel discipline focused on other religious traditions.

Almost a century later, the comparative study of religions emerged as a prominent field in the study of religions, characterised by the scientific principles of objectivity and neutrality. This shift represented a departure from the apologetic stance of mainstream theology. The comparative study of religion entered a postmodern crisis in the second half of the 20th century. The work of most of the old comparativists (Mircea Eliade and Gerardus van der Leeuw, for instance) was put under scrutiny, with the accusation that hegemony and imposition were inherent in the very process of comparing religions, calling into question its entire supposedly scientific approach.

In the contemporary context, characterised by its plurality and public nature, there is a resurgence of confidence in the comparative method and a renewed examination of methodological concerns in the study of religious phenomena. New comparative scholars have come to recognise the inherent value of comparison as an integral component of human knowledge and a potential means of comprehension in a pluralistic environment. Consequently, the argument for total incompatibility among religious traditions has proven

untenable, as evidenced by the existence of shared patterns that do not necessitate the adoption of a hegemonic or impositional posture.

4.2. Developments

Comparative theology is a field of study that involves the systematic comparison of religious doctrines, practices and beliefs. It goes beyond a simplistic scientific comparison of religions (comparative religion) to encompass a more nuanced and comprehensive analysis. A fundamental aspect of comparative theology is the understanding of at least two religious traditions, which requires the study of their respective texts, histories, teachings and rituals. It is important to note that any comparison is inherently premised on a particular aspect or issue that serves as the foundation for the comparison (*tertium comparationis*). It functions as a heuristic tool, which is perpetually open to elucidation and refinement. It may take the form of a generic theme, such as ultimate realities, love, the human condition, creation or knowledge in the different religions. Alternatively, it may be more specific, for example in the case of the different figures of salvific mediation, or certain rituals, texts or thinkers.

The overarching objective of comparative religion is to enhance one's comprehension of a religious phenomenon from an intellectual and scientific standpoint. In contrast, the primary objective of comparative theology is to further religious truth, thereby enriching the self-understanding of religious traditions and facilitating the spiritual transformation of religious seekers. The former pertains to the acquisition of knowledge *about* another religious tradition, while the latter involves the acquisition of knowledge *from* another religious tradition or the integration of the teachings of different religions with a view to transformation. The learning process can be understood in several directions, including intensification and rectification, recovery and reinterpretation, development and reaffirmation of the specificity of the truth of one or both traditions.

It is important to note that the common pursuit of truth through the medium of dialogue is at the very heart of comparative theology. This underscores its inherent public nature, as it is driven by the collective quest for truth that benefits all. As Cornille (2022)'s thought has shown, once the public dimension of comparative theology has been ascertained, four approaches can be indicated within it: the postcolonial, confessional, transreligious and interreligious approach. Each perspective possesses its own significance and should not be regarded in an exclusionary manner, as it is from their collective examination that the most can be gleaned. However, it is this author's opinion that the interreligious approach to comparative theology characterises the entire learning process the most.

The postcolonial approach to comparative theology is predicated on the deconstruction of hegemonic practices and untrue dichotomies that project the identity or belief system of one religion against that of another. The almost natural approach of opposing religious identities is radically questioned, while the cross-cultural comparison highlights differences and similarities that cut across religious boundaries, thereby creating a climate for a non-dominant form of interreligious theological learning (Nicholson 2011). As a fundamental tenet of comparative theology, postcolonialism provides a foundation for all approaches within this discipline. Consequently, it can be considered a 'safe ground' from which other, more constructive forms can emerge.

"A confessional comparative theology involves a process of engaging in constructive theological reflection with other religions from within the religious framework of a particular religious tradition" (Cornille 2022, p. 591). This tradition is the starting point for engagement with other traditions. It is also the point of reference and the criterion for determining the truth of the teachings and practices of another tradition. Only the teachings that are in continuity with, or not in contradiction with, the core teachings of one's own tradition will be considered as possible occasions for learning. This approach

is predicated on a reframing of 'faith seeking understanding' *in the other*, with the aim of refining one's own truth. It is a process that involves taking the other's position into consideration and finding a renewed meaning in one's faith only after confrontation with the other.

Comparative theology, understood as transreligious theology, is a form of encounter with the tenets and practices of another religion in which the home tradition does not play a normative role in engaging with religious diversity. As Hustwit (2016) asserts, a theologian who applies the outcomes of an encounter with another tradition to their own home tradition does so without necessarily seeking to align with any specific tenet of the traditions involved in the encounter. We could talk in this case of "understanding seeking faith" instead of "faith seeking understanding", as in the confessional approach, since "a commitment to a faith community is not necessary, at least not at the beginning" (Neville 2022, p. 432). According to Jerry Martin (2020, p. 1), a transreligious theology follows a simple syllogism:

> If the aim of theology is to know and articulate all we can about the divine or ultimate reality, and if revelations, enlightenments, and insights into that reality are not limited to a single tradition, then what is called for is a theology without confessional restrictions, a Theology Without Walls (TWW). Any approach that omits the insights of traditions other than one's own falls short of being adequate to the ultimate reality. Any approach that insists on translating those insights into the terms of one's own tradition risk narrowness, distortion, and misappropriation.

Lastly, the interreligious theological approach is predicated on the premise that both traditions engaged in comparative theological activity may be subject to "mutual illumination". Consequently, it may be situated between the confessional and the transreligious. In its essence, it is faithful to the fundamental tenets of both traditions, like the former, while not being confined to the enhancement of the truth of a single tradition, as is the case with the latter. According to Arvind Sharma (2005), comparison is the hallmark of the study of religion. However, whenever two items are compared in religious studies, there is a tendency towards 'theological reductionism', whereby one item of comparison is assimilated to the other. This tendency can be illustrated by the understanding of Christianity in terms of Hinduism, and vice versa. A 'methodological reductionism' may also occur, whereby a religious tradition is studied through the lens of a specific method (e.g., dogmatic, genetic, etc.). These represent forms of epistemological reductionism. However, a more profound reductionism, termed 'ontological', is posited when one item of comparison is regarded as an incomplete representation of the other. According to this ontological reductionism, Christianity is regarded as the crown of Hinduism. In the context of the reductionist approaches, the author posits the following hypothesis: what if we were to compare phenomena not to evaluate one element against another, but rather to observe how our comprehension of these elements is enriched in the process, or even in an alternative dimension of religious experience that was not initially considered? This methodology of comparison, which the author has designated as "reciprocal illumination", constitutes the central theme of much of his theological commitment.

The areas of possible mutual fertilisation or even compatibility between religions will be the subject of theological activity in this interreligious comparative approach. In this regard, the work of Aloysius Pieris' *Love Meets Wisdom* (1988) as well as the contribution of Raimon Panikkar ([1964] 1981) with his *The Unknown Christ of Hinduism*, and more on the Hindu side, his *The Vedic Experience: Mantramañjarī* (1977), could be considered. It is evident from the outset that *Mantramañjarī*, for instance, is explicitly public and interreligious in its rereading of the Vedic experience. In the preface, the author asserts that

the presentation of the Vedic experience has not emerged from the dilemma of choosing the sacred or the secular, the Church or the State. The fundamental insight of the Vedic experience, as outlined by the author, is that there is neither essence without existence nor existence without an essence. This suggests the possibility of a sacred secularity. This sacred secularity, it is argued, is one in which the Vedic experience is able to articulate a meaningful message to the modern human being. Simultaneously, the Vedic epiphany, one of the most remarkable expressions of the Spirit, constitutes a part of the collective heritage of humanity. Its most effective function, akin to that of numerous other religious and cultural values of humanity, is not preservation, but dissemination in a spirit of fellowship with humanity at large (Panikkar 1977, pp. xxxv–xxxvii).

It is evident that this interreligious comparative approach is characterised by its openness to the potential for mutual learning and the exchange of ideas between different traditions. Both parties involved are cognisant of the truths they present and are susceptible to the truths that the other brings to the fore. Furthermore, the majority of the subjects addressed, and the language employed by theologians engaged in comparative interreligious theology, have the capacity to resonate with diverse audiences, encompassing not only adherents of a single religious tradition, but also believers of various faiths and nones, those who do not belong to any religion. Consequently, their discourse assumes a public dimension, as it is able to address the cultural and religious dimensions that pertain to the common good, peaceful living, and the establishment of a more just society. This is achieved by minimising distortions and enhancing mutual understanding and peaceful coexistence.

In light of the emergent paradigm of religious pluralism and sacred secularity, the role of religion, and consequently its presence in educational institutions, is compelled to undergo a period of reflection and re-evaluation. Religion, it is proposed, should be recognised as a domain wherein religious phenomena are acknowledged, rather than silenced, and welcomed as a catalyst for human unity and the cultivation of fraternal bonds. Concurrently, the institution of religion should not be relegated to the domain of 'someone', but rather should be assumed by the State and religions collectively, without the constraints of competition or the threat of intrusion, while maintaining a stance of respect for established traditions (Olivero 2024). It is therefore possible to affirm that the educational project proposed by comparative public theology, in its diversity of approaches and unity of purpose, is capable of responding positively to the public role that religions are called to play in today's plural world. It provides an entry point to the complex issues of *how* to address religious education and interreligious learning in the context of public theology from different religious perspectives.

5. Interreligious Education and Comparative Public Theology

Interreligious collaboration has an intrinsic educational value. Furthermore, the provision of interreligious education is instrumental in supporting the global imperative of peace, justice and human rights. Interreligious education continues to emphasise that the world's religions uphold spiritual systems and religious values that repudiate violence and the pursuit of individual economic and political gains. In contrast, these religions advocate for the cultivation of love, understanding, and compassion for all individuals and the natural world. Furthermore, interreligious education aims to cultivate students' awareness of the necessity for followers of religions across the globe to cultivate and nurture dialogical relationships characterised by respect and understanding. A fundamental objective of interreligious education is to foster understanding and engagement between individuals of different religious affiliations and avoid behaviour that may stereotype or demonize

other people or various traditions, thereby contributing to the collective well-being of the global community.

It is possible to propose an advanced definition of interreligious education as a continuous and interactive process through which individuals learn *about*, learn *into*, and learn *from* religions and the diversity of religions.

Interreligious education is a multifaceted concept that encompasses cognitive, affective, and experiential dimensions. The cognitive dimension of religion (learn *about*) refers to the process of acquiring knowledge about the various facets of different world religions, encompassing their breadth and depth. The cognitive dimension is intricately interwoven with the affective process of assimilating this knowledge at a personal level (learning *into*), thereby integrating religious education into their personal and intellectual lives. Finally, interreligious education is characterised by an experiential dimension, whereby students are immersed in the religious world of other faiths, with a view to learning *from* these other traditions. This experiential dimension encompasses a range of activities, such as interaction among people of different faiths, listening and learning about the experience of other religions, visiting places of worship, hearing about festivals and holidays, and listening to favourite religious stories in the holy books.

The field draws upon a range of disciplines including comparative religion and theology, sociology and phenomenology of religion, religious education, philosophy of education, peace education, and critical and transcultural studies.

5.1. Towards a Model of Interreligious Education

For some time now, the pedagogical–religious sphere has brought to public attention the question of how to theoretically rethink Religious Education (RE) and Interreligious Education (IRE) in a public and plural context and how to implement the related programmes (Engebretson et al. 2010).

Hermans' contribution (2003) on this point appears to be of significance. He commences his analysis by delineating the distinction between mono-religious, multi-religious and inter-religious education.

These approaches are then evaluated according to the content of religions and goal of religious education. In relation to the content, three points are emphasised, as follows: It is imperative that religious change and innovation be encouraged. It is crucial to avoid the pernicious influences of religious imperialism whilst simultaneously recognising and safeguarding religious diversity. Religion should be acknowledged as a distinctive yet integral component of the intricate tapestry of personal and social life (public aspect of religion).

The goal of religious education is the development of an individual's religious identity, which is achieved through engagement in religious practices (learning *into*). Hermans' interpretation of participation is defined as "peripheral participation", signifying that participation entails both a degree of identification with a specific practice and a process of negotiation concerning its significance. In the absence of a comprehensive understanding of the practice's meaning, learning remains unattainable, and this can be viewed as a form of indoctrination.

5.1.1. Mono-Religious

Mono-religious education is an approach to religious instruction that is characterised by its exclusive focus on a single religion. This pedagogical approach is also referred to as a transmission model, given that its objective is the propagation of a specific tradition. It does not inherently entail a complete disregard of other religious traditions. Indeed, it may manifest itself in two distinct forms. As an example, in Christianity, the 'hard version'

is based on an exclusive focus on Christianity, operating on the premise that salvation is the exclusive domain of the Church (exclusivism). This approach treats religion as self-contained and all external influences as irrelevant. All other religions are collectively referred to as 'them' or non-Christian. Conversely, the 'soft version' considers other religions as potential avenues for salvation, viewed within the context of and in relation to the Christian truth (inclusivism). In both instances, Christianity is regarded as the prevailing paradigm, both in terms of exclusion and inclusion, with religions being acknowledged only to the extent that they do not contradict the Christian self-understanding.

The mono-religious education in the 'hard version' is entirely averse to changes in terms both of religion and society, since it completely neglects any context, and proceeds in 'splendid isolation'. This version is predicated on a return to the past. In contrast, the 'soft version' permits some degree of contextualisation of faith, both social and religious, and to a certain extent, it allows for change. However, both versions lack provision for religious diversity. The hard model entirely negates it, while the soft model allows for it only from a Christian perspective. Regarding the third criterion, the model does allow for recognition of the distinctiveness of religion; however, it completely disregards the public character of religion and its cohesive role in society, since there is no meaningful context in which to grasp what is peculiar and what is common to one's tradition.

This model could be summarised as: sufficient learning *into* religion (not as peripheral participation in the 'hard version', rarely in the 'soft version'): "the learning goal remains participation *in* practices rather than development *through* practices" (Hermans 2003, p. 340); good learning *about* a single tradition; no learning *from* religious traditions.

5.1.2. Multi-Religious

The approach of multi-religious education recognises the current pluralistic context. This diversity of religions in society is the horizon of religious education. Other religions are not seen from the point of view of a particular religion, but each is described in its own terms. The theological basis for this educational approach is known as pluralism in the theology of religions: the same soteriological goal is shared by all and all lead to it. The reason for the variety of ways is cultural differences, but the ultimate goal is the same: The Real (Hick 1995). In terms of content dimension, the model appears to demonstrate a limited degree of interest in change and innovation, as evidenced by its profound sensitivity to the religiously pluralistic environment in which individuals reside. Religions are regarded as self-contained entities that must be understood in their own terms, without consideration for their dynamics, whether diachronic or synchronic, and their relationship. While religious diversity is a source of inspiration for this model, it appears to exhibit characteristics of religious imperialism (Knitter 2002). The third criterion concerning content is that religion should be both a distinct part of personal and societal life and integrated with it. The multireligious model is a pertinent example of this. It accords considerable attention to the distinctive character of each religion. Furthermore, religion is interwoven with other cultural phenomena and the personal lives of individuals, albeit to a lesser extent. In fact, it has a tendency to regard religion as a self-contained phenomenon, with the emphasis exclusively on knowledge of the different religions.

In terms of the objective of religious education, this model adopts a neutral, descriptive approach to religions. Religions are primarily viewed from an external perspective, thereby failing to facilitate the process of individuals appropriating the meaning of practices within specific religions. This model can thus be summarised as follows: inadequate learning *into* religion (lacking interest in 'peripheral participation'), effective learning *about* traditions, and limited learning *from* religious traditions.

5.1.3. Inter-Religious

Following the multi-religious approach, inter-religious education is deeply aware of the religious pluralism in society in general and in universities in particular. It is not so much the neutral description of religions that is at the forefront of interreligious education, but rather the dialogue between followers of different religions (learning *into*). Of course, dialogue is not possible without knowledge about them, and acquiring such knowledge is part of the process of dialogue (learning *about* and learning *from*).

The interreligious approach to education is possible in two variants: the simple and the complex model. In the case of a dialogue based on a specific religion (simple dialogical model) and aimed at cultivating a particular religious identity (e.g., a Hindu identity), the model employed aligns closely with the tenets of confessional comparative theology. On the other hand, if the dialogue involves several religions with the aim of promoting different religious identities (e.g., Hindu and Christian), it is classified as a complex dialogical model, which has similarities with the approaches of transreligions and interreligious comparative theology.

The simple dialogic model requires individuals to possess knowledge, insight and involvement in a specific tradition (Hinduism), as observed in mono-religious education. However, in contrast to this model, inter-religious education aims to foster knowledge and insight into diverse religious traditions. It endeavours to comprehend these traditions based on their own self-understanding rather than from a Hindu perspective. This model aspires to facilitate learning *about* both Hinduism and other religions. However, the ultimate objective of acquiring knowledge about others is to enhance one's understanding of one's own tradition (Hinduism). Through dialogue, differently from mono- and multi-religious education, individuals can broaden their perspective (learning *from*) and deepen their engagement with their own tradition (learning *into*).

In a public and pluralistic context, such as that of schools and universities, the simple dialogical model is insufficient. A more sophisticated form of dialogue is proposed as an educational perspective, in which individuals alternately adopt the perspective of each of the different religions (complex model). The aim of this is to achieve a process of "mutual illumination" for each tradition and the people involved. Therefore, the auto-perspective of one religion is critically explored from the perspective of another religion and vice versa. In the case of Hinduism and Christianity, for example, it is possible to elaborate the homoeomorphic equivalence between *agape* and *bkati* as two different but correlated ways of God's love, and to open up new dimensions to both Christian and Hindu faith as knowledge, precisely through a mutual fecundation (Sabetta 2020). In this context, Sheridan (2007, p. 6) invites us to think of most sacred texts as 'catalysts' that "can help to grasp afresh our own tradition and to make it our own in a way adequate to the demands and challenges of the modern culture that we live in".

In addressing the three criteria concerning the content of religions, the model of inter-religious education is characterised by its extensive capacity for change and innovation, its openness to religious diversity (which is regarded as a positive asset), and its resistance to imperialism. Furthermore, it fully embodies the involvement of religions in the public sphere. With regard to the objective of religious education, this model fosters inter-religious dialogue as a means to enhance religious self-development, thereby contributing to the common good and the welfare of society. Therefore, the field of comparative interreligious and transreligious theology demands a comprehensive and coherent understanding of at least two religions, in addition to the capacity to engage in critical dialogue and to draw insights from multiple traditions. Furthermore, it necessitates a learning *into*, that is, a "peripheral participation" in more than a religious tradition, at least in the interreligious version (in the transreligious version, this dimension is dispensable, but still important).

Peripheral participation is not the initiation in a specific tradition, but rather to understand the other religion or a particular religious practice *from the inside*.

The above evaluation establishes the third approach, the inter-religious one, as the most effective, albeit with certain limitations. They pertain to the hermeneutical dimensions of dialogue concerning the objective and methodologies involved in understanding and learning from other perspectives: to what extent does inter-religious education effectively engage with the other? What does it mean to understand the other?

It has been suggested that these limitations can be addressed by referring to Taylor (1994)'s 'hermeneutics of recognition', according to which there is a close relationship between identity (being oneself) and recognition by the other. Therefore, recognition implies both equal respect and equality for all cultures and religions in terms of meanings and developments of self.

In addition, the criticisms of Taylor's position have the capacity to reorient it in terms of recognition of *distinctiveness* (people do not ask to be recognised as equal, they want recognition of what is peculiar to them); recognition of *suffering and injustice* (non-recognition of cultural distinctiveness is often accompanied by social and economic marginalization) and recognition of *otherness*.

In relation to the third point, four fundamental attitudes towards the 'otherness of the other' can be identified: the first being the tendency to equate the other with oneself; the second is the recognition of the other as a completely unknown entity; the third is the search for complementarity; and finally, the fourth is the capacity to be oneself in a foreign context.

The development of this fourth attitude, the most effective, depends on the simultaneous fulfilment of three conditions: the recognition of the other as alterity, the acceptance of the concept of my self-identity as being open to the otherness within me (the other is not extraneous, but rather constitutes the other part of me), and the pursuit of communion and co-existence. Furthermore, it is imperative to derive three hermeneutical attitudes from the preceding conditions. Firstly, the observer must maintain a detached perspective to accurately and neutrally perceive the other. Secondly, the observer must engage in participatory observation to comprehend the other in the other's own terms. Thirdly, the observer must acquire a comparative interpretation to identify a space for coexistence (Sundermeier 1999).

Finally, it is this author's opinion that these three conditions and three hermeneutical attitudes are completely satisfied by referring to the entire educational programme that Comparative Public theology proposes in terms of four approaches: the postcolonial, confessional, transreligious and interreligious (Valkenberg et al. 2022). Therefore, when considering pedagogical approaches, Comparative Public Theology emerges as a particularly effective and suitable methodology for interreligious education. This is due to its ability to fully address the three dimensions of learning *about*, learning *into*, and learning *from*.

6. Conclusions

Reading the signs of the times means addressing the public and pluralistic context in which we live (cf. Acts 17, 28), where the public dimension of religion has re-emerged in a situation of multiple religious presence. The public aspect has been addressed using the tool of Public Theology, leading to the identification of an inter-religious public theological space where different theological approaches can dialogue in the right direction, that is towards the common good. Religious plurality has been approached theologically through the lens of Comparative Theology, which has helped us to understand how dialogue is possible. The synthesis of this double movement has been identified as Comparative Public

Theology. Interreligious education is a plural and pluralistic environment that we have chosen to address through the lens of Comparative Public Theology. At the end of our analysis, Comparative Public theology emerges as a particularly effective and appropriate methodology for interreligious education. This is due to its ability to fully address the three dimensions of learning *about*, learning *into* and learning *from*.

Clooney (2001) offers a comprehensive definition of *fides querens intellectum*, articulating its essence as interreligious, comparative, dialogical and confessional in nature. The term 'interreligious' signifies its presence across traditions, and there are no good reasons today to keep theological traditions and theologies separate; this concept is further reinforced by the notion of 'comparative', which underscores the process of elucidation through comparisons, facilitated by the acknowledgement of a common ground; the term 'dialogical' is employed here in the sense of 'accountable'. This denotes the emerging necessity and capacity to justify one's position in such a manner that it is as accessible and comprehensible as possible to individuals both within and outside one's own tradition. In this author's opinion, this quality might be more appropriately designated 'public'; it is evident that the preceding reflections on theology as interreligious, comparative, and dialogical are intended to render more plausible the capacity of theologians to articulate their traditions' confessional claims, even in a decidedly pluralistic and public world. This brief description is, in the opinion of the author, not far from a tentative definition of Comparative Public Theology.

Funding: This research received no external funding.

Institutional Review Board Statement: Not applicable.

Informed Consent Statement: Not applicable.

Data Availability Statement: The original contributions presented in this study are included in the article. Further inquiries can be directed to the corresponding author.

Conflicts of Interest: The author declares no conflicts of interest.

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